

key equipment getting mired in red-tape, the department has been given sweeping powers to the DGP to purchase equipment up to Rs 25 lakh per unit. So if the state commissioner is to purchase 25 armoured vehicles costing less than Rs 25 lakh each, the DGP can clear it himself. While this sounds good on paper, it will be a success only when the DGP signs on the dotted line without any fear of becoming embroiled in a controversy.

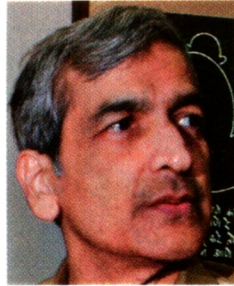
While the department has loosened its stranglehold on the police department, it is still far from giving the police additional freedom to carry out its business. The directives passed by the Supreme Court in the landmark *Prakash Singh vs Union of India* case in 2006 have not been followed in letter or spirit. Though a Police Establishment Board (PEB), which should decide all transfers, postings, promotions and other matters of police officers of and below the rank of DSP has been set up, it barely carries out its mandate as the Home Department addresses promotions and transfers of SP rank and above. Files pertaining to promotions and transfers still do the rounds of the Mantralaya, leaving scope for political intervention in key appointments. Officers are unhappy as the coterie culture has taken objectivity away from the PEB. As part of police reforms, the state also has to set up a police complaints authority at the district and state level and a security commission, which will lay down broad policies related to service-oriented functions. Even in cases where the PEB is looking into misconduct of personnel, the jurisdiction is restricted to inspectors and below.

While the Government may show



CHANDRA IYENGAR,
*Additional Chief Secretary
and Home Secretary 59*

Took over as home secretary in March 2009. Her focus is on decentralising power at the local level, police reforms and modernisation of the force.



HASAN GAFOOR,
DG (Housing) 57

Appointed as Mumbai police commissioner in March 2008. Shunted out as DG (Housing) before Pradhan Committee report was tabled in the Assembly.

BULLETPROOF JACKETS AND KALASHNIKOVS ARE THE NEW ACCESSORIES FOR POLICEMEN



MANDAR DEODHAR

its commitment to reforms, it is shying away from taking a stand when it comes to making police officials accountable. This has led to some ad hoc measures by the state. A recent example of its deft handling of the situation was the post-26/11 leadership debacle. While Gafoor was shown the door, the Government made it look like a promotion as he had to be given an

"honourable exit". While making it mandatory to have no more than four DG rank officers, the department created a fifth DG (Special Operations), a post given to Jayant Umranikar so that Gafoor could be accommodated as the new DG (Housing). Interestingly, it has taken the Home Department three months to work out the new DG's mandate and reporting structure. By doing this it is splitting the function of the DG's office into two silos. While the DGP will look into law and order situations, the DG (Special Operations) will look into insurgency and urban terror.

The state isn't the only one shying away. The same applies to thousands of over-sized, pot-bellied beat constables who are unable to perform their duties. While the commissioner has made provisions for a free-of-cost annual health check-up for nearly 40,000 men in the force, little will be done to penalise them if they don't conform to fitness standards. Says

Sivanandhan: "What can one do if they are not ready to stay fit?"

The 26/11 terror attacks may have shaken the department and the force into making changes in their operational structure but eight months on they are still in the work-in-progress stage. The intent may be right, but it will be long before the Government and the force can prove their might. ■